

As for Anisimova's abysmal performance (eight winners against 28 unforced errors), Evert provided a ready explanation. "Amanda had nothing left in the tank, emotionally and mentally. After every win, she fell and put her hands on her face. She was so happy. She wasn't used to that."

Although her dream run at the Big W ended in a nightmare final, Anisimova (below) notched two excellent wins and a huge one to arrive there. Faced with a much tougher draw than Swiatek, Amanda outslugged No. 30 Noskova of Czechia, 6-2, 5-7, 6-4 in the fourth

round and 2022 French Open finalist Anastasia Pavlyuchenkova, 6-1, 7-6(9), in the quarterfinals. She won the hard way against the 34-year-old Russian, not converting match points at 5-4 in the second set and then escaping set points at 6-3 in the tiebreak.

Amazingly, none of this year's quarterfinalists in the women's draw had reached the same stage at Wimbledon last year — and not one had ever made it to the final before.

That included, of course, Anisimova, who reached her second Grand Slam semifinal six years after making her first at the French Open

as a 17-year-old rising star who led Ash Barty by a set and 3-0 before bowing out. Three months later, her life was rocked when her father and long-time first coach, Konstantin, died of a sudden heart attack at 52, an event she called "the worst thing that ever happened to me".

Injuries and depression derailed her career, and in May 2023, she took an eight-month mental health break from the Tour. "A lot of people told me that you would never make it to the top again if you take so much time away from the game," she recalled. "That was a little hard to digest because I did want to come back and still achieve a lot and win a Grand Slam one day."



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During her time away from the tournament grind, Amanda renewed friendships, painted, and took college courses. When she returned to competition in January 2024, she regained her love of the game. "It's all about the process and enjoying every single day," she said.

After failing to qualify at Wimbledon a year ago, Anisimova racked up a 5-1 record against top-10 players this season. Though she was a decided underdog against Sabalenka in the semifinals, the 23-year-old American boasted a 5-3 edge in their rivalry. She also had the fastest serve return of any player — male or female — in the tournament.

Sabalenka, however, was under immense pressure in this tournament, having lost three-set heartbreakers to Madison Keys in the Australian Open final and Coco